

Research Question: How has the increase in accessibility of music production and distribution software affected the ability of black artists to retain more control over their art and the stories they tell?

Potential interviews: [Redveil beans and bars](#), [Mavi NOT97](#), [Vince Staples interview](#), [The Power of Selling Direct To Consumer – LaRussell](#) (LaRussell interview most important)

Articles:

- <https://www.theunsignedguide.com/blog/854-the-independent-musicians-guide-to-digital-distribution>

“Digital distribution is how you get your music onto platforms like Spotify and Apple Music. It is the process of managing and transferring your work in digital form to platforms that make the music more widely available.”

“(Streaming) This is the second, newer, way people access digital files. A digital music stream also creates a copy of the file, but unlike a download the listener does not get to keep the reproduced file; they can only listen to the audio by accessing it on their platform of choice.”

“Digital audio’s ease of use is what makes it so appealing to modern listeners”

“‘Why can’t an unsigned artist get their songs onto Spotify and Apple Music directly?’ To put it simply, you as the artist are not their customer. Your fans are their customers. These companies don’t want to take on the substantial service and development burden of dealing directly with millions of musicians”

“A distributor serves as a buffer between the creator of the music and the outlets that make that music available. But more importantly for you, you as the artist are saved a ton of time and work.”

- <https://defendernetwork.com/entertainment/is-technology-leveling-the-playing-field-for-black-artists/>

“Historically, Black music artists often faced challenges regarding creative control and ownership of their work. However, this new generation of performers enjoys more flexibility

thanks to independent distribution platforms and direct-to-consumer models. Artists are now more able to retain ownership rights, negotiate favorable contracts, and maintain creative autonomy.”

- <https://stories.sweetjuly.com/editorial/in-good-compenny-vallejo-artist-larussell-is-redefining-the-music-industry/>

“I basically created a stock for my music,’ says LaRussell. He also encourages fans to buy digital downloads and physical, signed CDs directly from him. And with his ‘Proud to Pay’ sliding-scale model, they pay whatever they want.”

“I had to be independent out of necessity,’ says LaRussell. ‘No one was looking for an artist from Vallejo to sign to their label. But through this, I was able to fulfill all my needs.”

- **Is the Music Industry Killing Creativity**

“Despite his success, however, Atlantic Records delayed his third album, Lasers, for two and a half years because they feared it lacked the commercial singles that they had envisioned for the project”

“Fiasco asserted... ‘don’t rap too deep on this record,’ confirming that the major record label had interfered with his ability to write freely and express himself as an individual through music.”

“His followers started a petition and planned to protest outside of the Atlantic Records headquarters while there was still a hold on the release of Lasers. The company quickly gave in and announced an official release date of March 8th, 2011”

“Lupe Fiasco’s statements on the dispute are proof that today’s music industry does not care about maintaining the artistic beauty of the product they sell, instead submitting to the overwhelming desire to top the Billboard charts and rake in millions of dollars, at the expense of the creative will and ability of profound lyricists like Lupe Fiasco.”

“Now, for the first time in many decades, all parties involved within the music industry value chain have the power to combat these issues and finally revive creative progress”

- **Aggregation Services and Songwriter Independence**

“Digital download aggregation services are the modern songwriter’s greatest ally and independent record labels’ newest competition”

“It is more cost effective than ever to record, mix, and distribute; and the competition online has increased as a result.”

“In the current age of music streaming services, musicians make little profit off of their popularity from their recorded music”

- Application of Digital Marketing Tools in the Music Industry

Passages from class:

- The Negro Tweet's his presence:

“allows for instantaneous visibility and therefore increased social capital/power—permit the articulation of a diversity of voices as well as new forms of civic participation. Twitter essentially enables each individual to be his or her own spokesperson.” (Redveil using twitter to promote his music)

- Social media: From Digital Divide to Empowerment

“In a very real way, these examples show how African Americans were able to disrupt the “distorting mirror” that Hall (1992: 14) argues traditional media hold up to reality and replace that mirror with messages they felt needed to be added to the public debate. Certainly, it would be misguided to attribute to a tweet or a status update the power

to overturn decades of inferential or overt racism. Yet clearly social media offered a new avenue to proclaim concerns for those who previously had few options.”

“Much of the power of social media to give people of color a voice is because it costs nothing, and ideas can rapidly gain currency across a large group of people.”

- Color Coded Thinking About Digital Networks

“Blackness for Sale thus reminds us that neither the words that we use to talk about computer networks nor the platforms we use to access the internet are neutral; the range of significations that accrue around color language and the embodied experiences that it recalls persist online as well as off.”

Explanation on Source Choices:

With the sources I chose I want to offer a brief history on how the messages and expressions of black artists were hindered prior to the development and accessibility of consumer music production and distribution software, how the existence of those software's and avenues help them in today's industry, and the limitations or drawbacks these developments have. While there are many examples, I used Lupe Fiasco's label

Select a passage from one of the 3 readings completed so far. Next take the time to explain how you see language working your life or as a tool for your use. Try to get a page.

Passage: A letter to that man who emailed me to correct my grammar

I partially agree with the author in their description of language as a math, although my disagreement lies more in that I see it as a science. Science is descriptive, rather than prescriptive like math, meaning that its theories, hypotheses, and conclusions are dependent and describe what is observed after repeated trials. In my life I've seen language work in this same way. What words communicate best the idea or concept I have in my head, is not an exact unchanging answer, but rather an evolving formula and calculus. One day a certain sentence or phrase might be sufficient in getting an idea across to whatever audience I'm communicating to, in the manner I'm looking for, and the next day it may not be. As a utilizer and student of language, the onus is on me to manipulate my formula of sentence construction, grammar rules, timing, aphorisms, and gestures, to achieve the desired result I'm looking to observe.

Understanding that language is a science makes it a more effective tool to use in daily life. It forces me to be more intentional with what words I say, how I say them, and who I say them to, being that I can recall from previous observation and know the likely effect my language will have and how effective it can be in communicating the ideas I want. It also changes the way you hear or read from others, you may analyze more closely the word choice or placement in one's speech and what they may have or may not have intended to communicate. Sometimes that attentiveness is unconscious and can come across as reading too deep into something, like I'd imagine some people must've taken the author to be doing, and other times it may be a conscious effort to come to a more accurate understanding of the other person.

Based on your reading of Baldwin and Re-Reading of Imani Perry, is there a black way of using technology? What is the relationship between one's voice as a writer and the kinds of writing technologies that one uses?

I would say yes and no. I don't think there's a universal way that black people use technology whether that be across the diaspora or even regionally in the US. However, I do think the way blackness is policed across society influences how black people interact with technology. In a similar way that in the US there is an apprehension black people display towards medicine and the healthcare industry as a result of injustices on black bodies historically in that industry, the same can happen with technologies. And in the same way that folk medicinal practices were created as response, black people in online communities and other tech spaces might develop their own insular communities, ways of communicating, and ways of using technologies (EX: Fizz). There are also ways in which scarcity or lack of access to resources becomes the impetus for certain innovations/different usages of technologies (not necessarily electronic) and become shared experiences amongst black people. This ranges from storing and reusing grocery bags, to cooking grilled cheese sandwiches with an iron. But these examples are not necessarily unique to black people, or even recognizable to all black people.

If voice is synonymous with identity, then I think it's pretty correlative to the kinds of writing technologies that one uses, as identity is greatly influenced by socialization. What can be defined as a writing technology is also very broad, and can range from genres, styles of literatures, and the physical tool and methods one uses to write. Race, class, gender, and other forms of subjective experience can be determinative factors in what writing technologies a person has access to use their voice through, and they can also be limiting factors in how useful a certain technology may be. For example, a Black academic might be less likely to use generative AI to aid their writing than a White businessman, because the functioning of AI might limit their voice, and unable to fully represent the ideas they convey using the same language. Additionally, there is more at stake for the Black academic, as the way their usage of AI will be received differently as a result of differing audiences, and historical biases.

- “Language, incontestably, reveals the speaker. Language, also, far more dubiously, is meant to define the other--and, in this case, the other is refusing to be defined by a language that has never been able to recognize him.”
- “A language comes into existence by means of brutal necessity, and the rules

of the language are dictated by what the language must convey.”

MLA sources

Luu, Chi. “Black English Matters.” *JSTOR Daily*, 12 Feb. 2020, daily.jstor.org/black-english-matters/.

Carver, Jessie. “African-American Vernacular English Is a Dialect. Period.” *Certified Languages International*, 24 Feb. 2022, certifiedlanguages.com/blog/african-american-vernacular-english-is-a-legitimate-dialect/.